

Gian Luca Potestà, *Il tempo dell'Apocalisse. Vita di Gioacchino da Fiore* (Roma - Bari 2004)

In his ambitious study, Gian Luca Potestà, already editor of two of Joachim's earlier writings ('Dialogi de prescientia Dei et predestinatione electorum', *Fonti per la Storia dell'Italia Medievale*, Antiquitates 4, Rome 1995, and 'Genealogia', *DA* 56/2000, p. 91-101) presents the first monograph on the life and work of Joachim of Fiore (ca. 1135-1202) since the groundstaking "Influence of Prophecy" by Marjorie Reeves back in the 1960s. Other than the English scholar, Gian Luca Potestà concentrates on Joachim's own lifetime and his immediate surroundings. The biography of the Calabrian abbot is linked and interwoven with the main events of contemporaneous history and the abbot's literary production which emerges over nearly three decades, from the first text of 1176 until his unfinished late works.

In the first of 12 chapters, the author first provides an overview on the state of research and the extant sources. Then he follows Joachim's traces from the first notices of his biography until he became Abbot of Corazzo, the attempts to affiliate his monastery to the Cistercian houses of Sambucina and Casamari, his stay in Casamari and the beginnings of his literary production there, his treatise to and on Jews and the confrontation with heretics, the development of his trinitarian theology of history and the awareness of the approaching end of times and the expectation of the age of the Holy Spirit. He describes Joachim's ambiguous attitude towards secular power confronted with those of his contemporaries, mainly his enemy Goffrey of Auxerre, and Joachim's ascent to the Sila mountains in the Calabrian heartland, where he founded his new order. He describes Joachim's explanation of Revelation and the conclusions that followed this occupation, until towards the end of Joachim's life, when he tried to finish his latest writings, and wrote his testamentary letter which is preserved in the Venetian prints of 1527 and many of the manuscripts containing his writings.

The author tries to sort out not only Joachim's sources but also contemporaneous influences and oral informations which left their traces in Joachim's writings. He introduces and explains Joachim's imaginative thinking which depicts the history of salvation in biblical and classical motives such as the David's Psalter, Ezechiel's wheels or Paulinian lists of concords between Old and New Testament. Moreover, the author takes part in the ongoing debates on dating the main events of Joachim's life and the chronology of his writings, often questioning the too long unquestioned data.

Many tables, diagrams and tables enable the reader to visualize the abbot's figurative thought, as interpreted by Gian Luca Potestà. A rich bibliography and a mostly, though not always precise index list are helpful tools.